

RANJAN RAHI

WHAT MAKES HER A SHERO

Dolly turned her village's *gram kachahari* into an effective grassroots justice system, helping resolve nearly 700 disputes over land claims, widows' inheritance rights and family feuds

Bringing Closure

DOLLY, 36
Sarpanch, Sadipur village
Gaya, Bihar

Lined up on steel racks inside Dolly's modest residential office are more than 700 brown case files, each carrying the same typed inscription: Case Closed. It has become a quiet signature of the 36-year-old village sarpanch's style of governance—resolving conflicts through dialogue, persuasion and compromise rather than years of litigation.

Politics was never part of her plan. Raised in Meerut, Dolly studied for an MBA in Pune and later worked in the ticketing department of an aviation firm. Marriage changed both her address and her future. In 2014, she married documentary filmmaker and entrepreneur Dharmveer Bharti and moved to Gaya. After the death of her mother-in-law Neelam Devi, who was the sarpanch of Sadipur, the family persuaded Dolly to contest the 2018 byelection. She scraped through by just 130 votes against seven male candidates.

The real battle began after the election. Many villagers approached her husband instead of her, assuming she was merely a nominal sarpanch. Weeks of patiently hearing complaints, conducting site inspections and delivering fair verdicts gradually established that she was the one in charge—not the men around her.

Today, Sadipur's 20,000 residents bring to her the disputes that define rural life: ancestral property quarrels, land claims, domestic conflicts and widows seeking their legal share of family assets. Dressed in a sari, Dolly is often seen riding her Scooty across Gaya, usually with another elected woman representative riding pillion, persuading reluctant relatives to sit together and negotiate. Under her stewardship, disputes that could drag through civil courts for years are often resolved within six months. Re-elected in 2021, she has helped settle over 700 disputes so far, even as she balances village governance with raising her two young children—an eight-year-old daughter and a one-year-old son. ■

—Amitabh Srivastava

HER TAKE

"Education gives you confidence; leadership is about using that confidence to solve people's problems. Women should never hesitate to step forward when they have the opportunity"